Global cooperation

Scientists have known that human actions contribute to climate change since 1896, when Swedish scientist Svante Arrhenius suggested that people burning fossil fuels were adding to global warming. Only in the 1970s, however, did governments began to act upon this knowledge. Around this time, the general public had begun to be made aware of the reality of climate change due to news articles and broadcasts that shared the bleak outlooks of climate scientists with the wider world.

International efforts to halt or delay climate change began with the first United Nations conference on the environment, held in 1972 in Stockholm, Sweden. The conference paid little attention to the issue of climate change compared to other environmental issues—such as pollution and renewable energy—but did create the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP), an agency to oversee environmental policies and programs such as ecosystem management, natural disaster relief, and antipollution activities. UNEP later became responsible for coordinating UN efforts against climate change.

In 1987, UN members also agreed to the Montreal Protocol, pledging to protect Earth’s ozone layer by ending the use of ozone-depleting substances. While not specifically designed to combat climate change, the agreement, which was ratified by all UN member states, did reduce greenhouse gas emissions.